

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS



INDIA-MYANMAR - 2

MODULE - 31

INDO-MYANMAR BORDER

India and Myanmar have several political, security and economic concerns that hinder the relationship between the two countries.

- 1 The construction of border fence by Myanmar has led to resentment among the people on both sides of the Indo-Myanmar border.
- 2 It would deprive them of the produce from their land and forest resources.
- 3 From the security perspective, possible anti-establishment sentiments could destroy the peace along the Indo-Myanmar border.



ROHINGYA MUSLIMS ISSUE

The Rohingya crisis is a political issue in Myanmar

- 1
 - More than one million people comprise the Rohingya community in Myanmar.
 - It is an ethnic minority; predominantly Muslim group living mainly in Rakhine State on the country's western coast.
- 2 These people lack documentation to satisfy the constitutional requirement that their ancestors settled in the country before 1823.
- 3 Myanmar is a Buddhist majority country.

Finding safe haven in Bangladesh

Hundreds of thousands of Rohingya have left their ethnic homeland of Rakhine State for the district of Cox's Bazar in Chittagong, Bangladesh.



ROHINGYA MUSLIMS ISSUE

- 4 It has not granted full citizenship to Rohingyas as it considers them as migrated who fled their land during colonial period.
- 5 Since the 1970's, thousands of Rohingyas have fled Myanmar due to its discriminative policies.
- 6 Most have taken shelter in Bangladesh, India, Indonesia, Malaysia and Thailand by land and sea routes.



ROHINGYA MUSLIMS ISSUE

WHEN DID THE ISSUE ARISE?

- 1 Since 2016, Myanmar's army has carried out "clearance operations" in the north of the western state to root out insurgents accused of deadly raids on police border posts.
- 2 UN human rights office said that Myanmar's security forces had committed mass killings and gang rapes of Rohingya Muslims and burned their villages.
- 3 In March 2017, 423 detainees were put arrested which includes women and children.
- 4 The crisis resulted in the displacement of nearly 92000 people from their homeland.
- 5 The Myanmar military attacks resulted into largest human exodus in Asia.
- 6 It was declared as "ethnic cleansing" and "genocide" by various UN agencies.



ROHINGYA MUSLIMS ISSUE

EFFECT OF GOVERNMENT INTERVENTION

- 1** Many Rohingya have fled to neighbouring Bangladesh, alleging rape, murder and torture at the hands of security forces. A large number of those escaping the violence end up in the trafficking networks.
- 2** The persecuted Rohingya Muslims are likely to provide fertile recruiting grounds for extremists.
- 3** Bangladesh fears that Islamist hard-liners, who staunchly support the Rohingya Muslims, are trying to exploit the situation for their political benefits.
- 4** Some sections of the Rohingyas have formed armed guerilla groups in Rakhine to fight Myanmar's Army and operate along the mountainous border.
- 5** Despite Myanmar's transition towards democracy, the country's government refuses to address the issue.



ROHINGYA MUSLIMS ISSUE

INDIA'S RESPONSE

- 1 India has been receiving Rohingya refugees and allowing them to settle in the different parts of the country over the years, especially after the communal violence in the state of Rakhine in 2012.
- 2 Since India is not a signatory to the United Nations Convention on Refugees, refugee status granted by the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) to the Rohingya was irrelevant to their deportation.
- 3 India faces tremendous burden on its resources on account of Rohingya refugees and faces security threat because of the radicalized Rohingya youth.
- 4 India hosts around 40,000 Rohingya Muslims who have sought refuge in India fearing religious persecution in Myanmar.



Why is India turning its back on Rohingyas?

ROHINGYA MUSLIMS ISSUE

INDIA'S RESTRAINT

India does not proactively intervene to resolve the Rohingya issue as:

- 1 India considers the issue as an internal affair of Myanmar.
- 2 India believes that ASEAN has an undeniable responsibility to resolve this crisis.
- 3 India does not want a conflict of interests with the new regime in Myanmar

- 4 Myanmar has a key role in India's Look East Policy.



ROHINGYA MUSLIMS ISSUE

IN RECENT NEWS

- 1 On 23 January 2020, UN's international court of justice ordered Myanmar to take urgent measures to protect its Rohingya community against violence and to preserve evidence of past attacks.
- 2 But Myanmar's army claimed that it was only fighting Rohingya militants and denied targeting civilians.
- 3 The country's leader Aung San Suu Kyi, has repeatedly denied allegations of genocide.



ROHINGYA MUSLIMS ISSUE

RESOLUTION OF THE PROBLEM

- 1 The ultimate solution lies in the granting citizenship and ensuring equal rights in their ancestral home.
- 2 Until a permanent solution is found in Myanmar, it is the responsibility of refugee hosting countries, including Bangladesh, to ensure that Rohingya people can live with basic human rights and dignity.
- 3 International community needs to play more proactive role in resolving present crisis.



ROHINGYA MUSLIMS ISSUE

RESOLUTION OF THE PROBLEM

- 4 Due to lack of economic interest in Myanmar, western world is not very enthusiastic to resolve the crisis and deals it as internal problem of Myanmar.
- 5 There is a conflict between Bangladesh and Myanmar regarding the Rohingya issue.
- 6 It would be interesting to see how will India will balance its relationship with the two countries- whether India would be able to make a resolution to Rohingya crisis and how the implications of CAA and NRC will impact it's relationship with Myanmar.



ECONOMIC

1. POWER PROJECT

- 1 Due to construction of hydro electrical projects on two tributaries of the Kaladan river, navigation of boats could be affected.
- 2 Cost of the projects has risen due to the delays. According to MEA, the project monitoring activities are not being done efficiently and effectively.
- 3 Fragile and pristine environment of the North East may be affected as the region is a biodiversity hotspot especially in the region from Paletwa to the Indian Myanmar border as land acquisitions and local displacement may be required.



ECONOMIC

2. CONNECTIVITY PROJECT

- 1 The Kaladan project and improved connectivity & transportation facility is expected to improve the overall development of the region.
- 2 But the Rakhine and Chin states have very poor transport and communication infrastructure making it difficult to fully develop agriculture, trade and commerce



3. TRADE

- 1 Trade between India and Myanmar is far below potential.
- 2 A major reason is the slow work on infrastructure projects.
- 3 Myanmar exports to India have been impacted because India imposed restrictions on import of pulses to improve the price realization of its Indian farmers

CHINESE PRESENCE

The friendship between China and Myanmar is a win-win situation for both countries.

1 China has played a major role in the peace negotiations between the armed ethnic groups and Myanmar government.

2 In return, Myanmar helps China in getting access to natural resources, access to Bay of Bengal and concession to build a Special Economic Zone.

3 Myanmar wishes to be a stakeholder in OBOR by getting a controlling stake in a natural deep sea harbor at Kyaukpyu.

4 India is apprehensive of the growing Chinese presence in its neighbourhood



VISIT OF MYANMAR'S PRESIDENT TO INDIA

1 On 26 February 2020, Myanmar's President U. Win Myint visited India. PM Modi and President Myint signed following agreements in various fields including infrastructure, energy, communication and health.

2 The two sides also announced the launch of a bus service between Imphal in Manipur and Mandalay in Myanmar from April 7 as part of efforts to improve connectivity and people-to-people contacts.

3 Mou on 'Cooperation for Prevention of Trafficking in Persons; Rescue, Recovery, Repatriation and Re-Integration of Victims of Trafficking'.



VISIT OF MYANMAR'S PRESIDENT TO INDIA

4 Indian Granted Assistance for Implementation of Quick Impact Projects (QIP)

5 India expressed support for Myanmar's peace process between Government, Military and Ethnic Armed Groups.

6 Three agreements for development projects in the conflict-torn Rakhine state were also signed.



FUTURE OF INDO-MYANMAR RELATIONS

- 1 Myanmar is India's land bridge to Southeast Asia.
- 2 Besides being the closest Southeast Asian neighbour, Myanmar's long porous international border with Northeast India, India's quest for connectivity with East Asia, India's search for alternative sources of energy, and its economic linkages with the region- all indicate a close relationship with the country.
- 3 With the renewed emphasis on India's 'Act East' policy, the bilateral relations between these two countries are expected to grow
- 4 India can thereby become an assertive regional player in Asia



FUTURE OF INDO-MYANMAR RELATIONS

5 India needs to seize this opportunity and expedite the work on ongoing projects while at the same time exercising soft power through constructive aid and cultural exchange.

6 Any bilateral relationship between neighbouring countries should be considered in the larger matrix of regional development.

7 India can also take cues from China to develop itself domestically, as well as, work on its soft power.



INTERNATIONAL BUDDHIST CIRCUIT

- 1** President Kovind inaugurated the 'International Buddhist Conclave (IBC), 2018 under North East India Circuit of Swadesh Darshan Scheme of Ministry of Tourism.
- 2** It was inaugurated in collaboration with the state governments of Maharashtra, Bihar and Uttar Pradesh and was followed by site visits to Rajgir, Nalanda and Bodhgaya (Bihar) and Sarnath (Uttar Pradesh).
- 3** The Ministry launched its website landofbuddha.in and a new film showcasing the Buddhist sites in the country.
- 4** The participants of the conclave suggested development of a special museum where the centuries old statue of Lord Buddha, all artefacts and objects related to Buddhism can be placed at a single location to view



INTERNATIONAL BUDDHIST CIRCUIT

5 The 13 thematic circuits under the Swadesh Darshan scheme are North East India Circuit, Buddhist Circuit, Himalayan Circuit, Coastal Circuit, Krishna Circuit, Desert Circuit, Tribal Circuit, Eco Circuit, Rural Circuit, Spiritual Circuit, Ramayana Circuit, Heritage Circuit and Wildlife Circuit.

6 Swadesh Darshan Scheme is a 100 percent centrally funded scheme and encourages leveraging voluntary funding under Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiatives of Central Public Sector Undertakings and corporate sector

अतुल्य भारत



Ministry of Tourism
Government of India

Incredible India

SWADESH
DARSHAN

BUDDHIST CIRCUIT

1 Ministry of Tourism has decided to expand Buddhist tourism circuit under Swadesh Darshan Scheme to 21 more states to make it India's first trans-national tourist circuit.

2 It includes Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Kerala, West Bengal, Goa, Gujarat and Jammu & Kashmir.

3 It includes Kapilavastu and Lumbini (Buddha's birthplace) in Nepal, Shravasthi, Sarnath, Kushinagar, Rajgir, Vaishali, and Bodhgaya in India.

4 The expansion of Buddhist tourism circuit aims to incorporate new-age Buddhist tourists from the West, apart from traditional tourists in South East Asia.



BUDDHIST CIRCUIT

- 5 Infrastructure development activities like tourist information centre, meditation centre, organic eco-tourism centre, log huts, zip line, flower exhibition centre, walkways, souvenir shops, cafeteria, rain shelters, wayside amenity, last mile connectivity, parking, public toilets, etc. have been developed under this project.
- 6 Ministry of Tourism has identified stupas and viharas in these 21 states, around which small intra-state Buddhist zones will be developed.
- 7 The Ministry of Tourism has decided to announce Buddhist circuit from India to Nepal as its first trans-national tourist circuit to attract Buddhist tourists to India.
- 8 The ministry is in talks with World Bank and Japanese government for funding of infrastructure projects connected with Buddhist tourism circuit.



IMPORTANCE OF BUDDHIST CIRCUIT

- 1 Buddhism is the fourth largest religion of the world and the development of this circuit is expected attract more foreign followers of Buddhism to India.
- 2 India is home to seven of the eight Buddhist sites, yet receives less than 1% of the Buddhist pilgrims in the world.
- 3 The inflow of foreign tourists will not only lead to increased inflow of foreign exchange earnings of India but will also generate large amount of employment for the local people
- 4 The circuit would focus on connectivity and the centralisation of functions and facilities. With the increasing commoditisation of religious tourism, circuits are a tool for pooling resources to maximize infrastructure and building brand



IMPORTANCE OF BUDDHIST CIRCUIT

5 As an marketing strategy for state governments, religious circuits help to standardise and segment the intangible experience of tourism into a thematised and saleable product.

6 Emotions and ritual practices can be used to strengthen national and cultural identity (such as the Sarv Dharma circuit), as well as provide significant economic benefits for the state.

7 Religious circuits also appeal to non-resident Indians and high-income pilgrim groups from abroad.

8 The appeal of Buddhist heritage in Pan Asian terms and has paved the way for a significant revival movement and mushrooming of Buddhist monasteries and temples



CHALLENGES TO BUDDHIST CIRCUIT

- 1 The Members of Parliament raised issues related to their constituencies with respect to the development of Buddhist circuit.
- 2 They highlighted the issue of connectivity which is standing in the way of development of tourism in these areas.
- 3 The MPs suggested that a Buddhist National Highway should be created connecting the important places within the circuit.



HIGHLIGHTS	
AGREEMENT	Between state government and International Finance Corporation to boost tourist inflow to Buddhist pilgrimage sites.
MONEY MATTERS	● Rs 55 crore would be spent on development of Buddhist circuit in Bihar and Uttar Pradesh ● 50 per cent of the amount would be given by International Finance Corporation ● Union ministry of tourism would contribute 40 per cent ● 5 per cent would be borne by the Bihar and UP governments
DISCORD	Focus of International Finance Corporation ● Beautification ● Parks at Buddhist circuit
	STATE'S INTEREST ● Infrastructure ● Budget hotels ● Public washrooms and toilets ● Light

CHALLENGES TO BUDDHIST CIRCUIT

4 The MPs also wanted improved air connectivity by developing airports at Kushinagar and Shravasti, development of budget hotels, common amenities and infrastructure in these areas were discussed during the meeting.

5 It remains to be seen how the Indian state seeks to regulate and manage these Buddhist pilgrimage flows and the existing organisational infrastructure that supports them through various monastic centres and pilgrim lodging.

6 At the recent meeting of the SAARC working group, representatives from Pakistan and Afghanistan too expressed interest in promoting their Buddhist sites in collaboration with India.



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For Suggestions:

suggestions@learningspace.in

To Contact us:

info@learningspace.in

For Information:

info.learningspacedigital@gmail.com

Visit us at:

www.learningspacedigital.com

0866 244 44 72

98499 42299

94415 27588